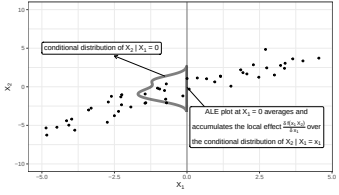
Interpretable Machine Learning

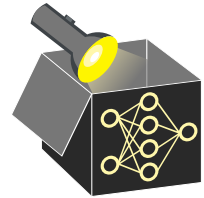
Accumulated Local Effect (ALE) plot



Learning goals

- Understand ALE plots
- Difference between ALE and PD plots

ACCUMULATED LOCAL EFFECTS (ALE) ▸ Apley, Zhu (2020)



ALE plots estimate the marginal effect of a feature by accumulating its local effects (integrating partial derivatives), evaluated in regions supported by the data.

Computation Steps:

1. **Estimate local effects** $\frac{\partial \hat{f}(x_S, \mathbf{x}_{-S})}{\partial x_S}$ (via finite differences)
   $\Rightarrow$ Removes unwanted main effects of other features $\mathbf{x}_{-S}$ (unlike M plots)

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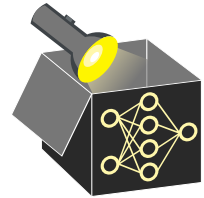

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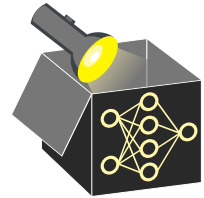

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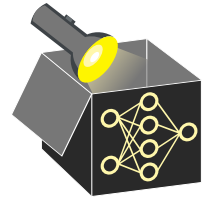
2. **Average local effects** over conditional distribution $\mathbb{P}(\mathbf{x}_{-S}|x_S)$ similar to M plots
   $\Rightarrow$ Avoids extrapolation (unlike PD plots)
3. **Accumulate:** Integrate averaged local effects up to a specific value $x \sim \mathbb{P}(x_S)$
   $\Rightarrow$ Reconstructs main effect of x_S

FIRST ORDER ALE FUNCTION



Uncentered ALE Function evaluated at $x \in \mathcal{X}_S$ (domain of feature x_S):

$$\tilde{f}_{S,\text{ALE}}(x) = \underbrace{\int_{z_0}^{x}}_{\text{acc.}} \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{x}_{-S}|x_S=z_S}}_{\text{average locally}} \left(\underbrace{\frac{\partial \hat{f}(z_S, \mathbf{x}_{-S})}{\partial z_S}}_{\text{local effect}} \right) dz_S = \int_{z_0}^{x} \int \frac{\partial \hat{f}(z_S, \mathbf{x}_{-S})}{\partial z_S} d\mathbb{P}(\mathbf{x}_{-S} \mid z_S) dz_S$$

- x_S is feature of interest, with minimum value $z_0 = \min(x_S)$
- z_S is integration variable ranging over $\mathcal{X}_S$, used to evaluate local effects
- $\mathbf{x}_{-S}$ denotes all other features (complement of S)

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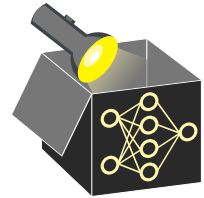

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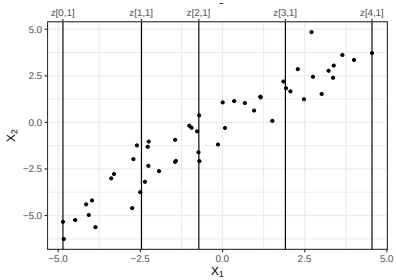
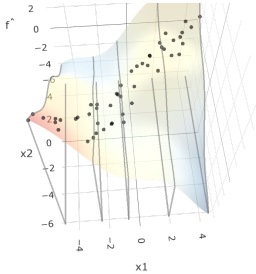
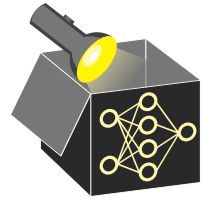
Centering (to ensure identifiability):

$$f_{S,\text{ALE}}(x) = \tilde{f}_{S,\text{ALE}}(x) - \underbrace{\int \tilde{f}_{S,\text{ALE}}(x_S)\, d\mathbb{P}(x_S)}_{\text{constant shift to mean zero}}$$

ALE ESTIMATION: ILLUSTRATION







- **Motivation:** Partial derivatives are not well-defined for all models (e.g., tree-based methods). $\Rightarrow$ Use finite differences within intervals instead.
- Partition the feature range of x_S into K intervals (vertical lines)
  - Define intervals:

$$x_S \in [\min(x_S), \max(x_S)] \Rightarrow x_S \in [z_0, z_{1,S}] \cup [z_{1,S}, z_{2,S}] \cup \cdots \cup [z_{K-1,S}, z_{K,S}]$$

  - *Equidistant*: preserves resolution
  - *Quantile-based*: balances sample size per interval

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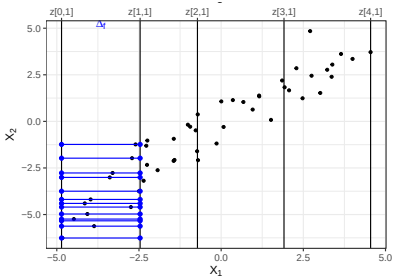

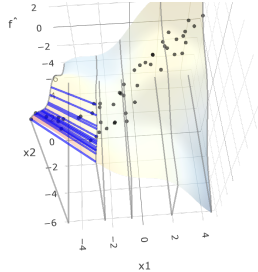

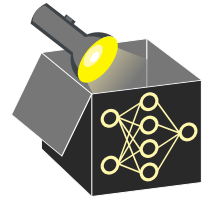

- For each observation in k-th interval, i.e., $\{i : x_S^{(i)} \in [z_{k-1,S}, z_{k,S}]\}$:
  - Replace $x_S^{(i)}$ with upper/lower interval bounds, keeping $\mathbf{x}_{-S}^{(i)}$ fixed
  - Compute observation-wise finite difference of i-th obs. in k-th interval
    $\rightsquigarrow \hat{f}(z_{k,S}, \mathbf{x}_{-S}^{(i)}) - \hat{f}(z_{k-1,S}, \mathbf{x}_{-S}^{(i)})$ (approximates local effect)

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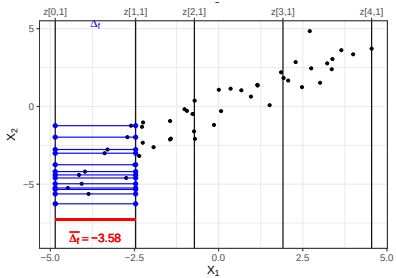

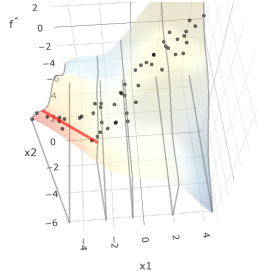

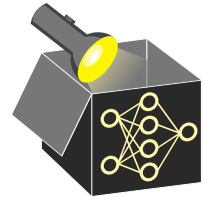

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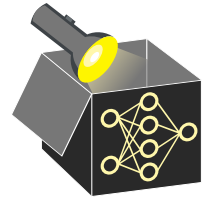
- Average these finite differences over all observations in each interval
  $\rightsquigarrow$ Approximates **inner integral** $\mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{x}_{-S}|x_S=z_S}\left[\partial\hat{f}/\partial z_S\right]$
- Accumulate these averages from z_0 to the point of interest $x \in \mathcal{X}_S$
  $\rightsquigarrow$ Approximates **outer integral** over $z_S \in [z_0, x] \Rightarrow$ uncentered ALE function

ALE ESTIMATION: FORMULA



Estimated uncentered ALE: For a point $x \in \mathcal{X}_S$, define:

$$\hat{\tilde{f}}_{S,ALE}(x) = \sum_{k=1}^{k_S(x)} \frac{1}{n_S(k)} \sum_{i:\ x_S^{(i)} \in [z_{k-1,S}, z_{k,S}]} \left[\hat{f}(z_{k,S}, \mathbf{x}_{-S}^{(i)}) - \hat{f}(z_{k-1,S}, \mathbf{x}_{-S}^{(i)}) \right]$$

- $[z_{k-1,S}, z_{k,S}]$: k-th interval of feature x_S
- $k_S(x)$: index of the interval in which x lies
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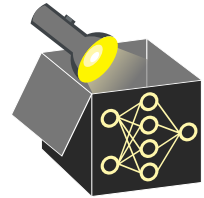

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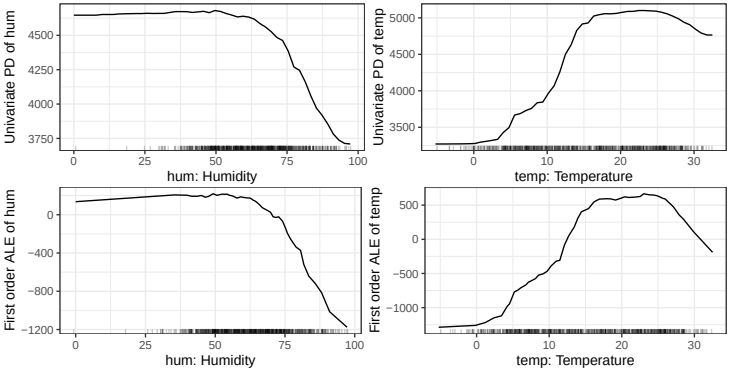
Centering: Ensure identifiability by subtracting the average uncentered ALE:

$$\hat{f}_{S,\text{ALE}}(x) = \hat{\tilde{f}}_{S,\text{ALE}}(x) - \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^{n} \hat{\tilde{f}}_{S,\text{ALE}}(x_S^{(i)})$$

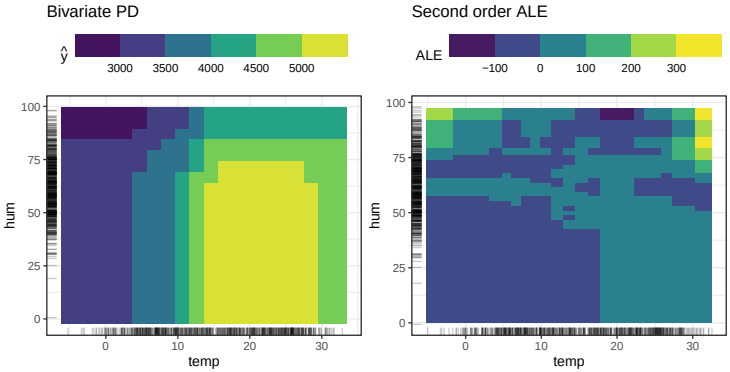
BIKE SHARING DATASET: FIRST ORDER ALE

Shape of PD plot (top) often looks similar to (centered) first order ALE plot (bottom) but on different y-axis scale. In case of correlated features, ALE might be better due to PD's extrapolation issue.

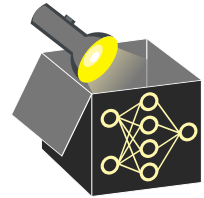


BIKE SHARING DATASET: SECOND ORDER ALE

Unlike bivariate PD plots, 2nd-order ALE plots only estimate pure interaction between two features (1st-order effects are not included).



PD VS. ALE



PD:

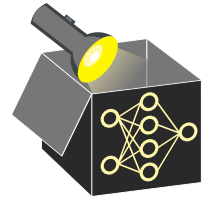
$$f_{S,PD}(x_S) = \mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{x}_{-S}}\left(\hat{f}(x_S, \mathbf{x}_{-S})\right)$$

ALE:

$$f_{S,\text{ALE}}(x) = \int_{z_0}^{x} \mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{x}_{-S}|x_S=z_S}\left(\frac{\partial \hat{f}(z_S, \mathbf{x}_{-S})}{\partial z_S}\right) dz - \text{const}$$

- Recall: PD directly averages predictions over marginal distribution of $\mathbf{x}_{-S}$
- ALE is faster: Needs $O(2 \cdot n)$ model calls vs. $O(n \cdot g)$ for PD with g grid points
- Difference 1: ALE averages
  - prediction changes (via partial derivatives, estimated by finite differences)
  - over conditional distribution $\mathbb{P}(\mathbf{x}_{-S}|x_S = z_S)$

PD VS. ALE



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- Difference 2: ALE integrates these partial derivatives over $z_S \in [z_0, x] \subseteq \mathcal{X}_S$
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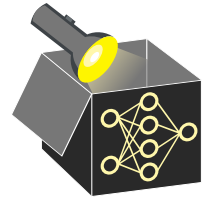

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- Difference 3: ALE is centered so that $\mathbb{E}_{x_S}\left(f_{S,ALE}(x)\right) = 0$